Chapter Seventy-Seven

The Disintegration of Delhi

Between 1352 and 1388,
the sultan of Delhi exercises kindness,
the Shah of Bengal cultivates mysticism,
and the rulers of the south spend all their time fighting

In Delhi, the reluctant Firoz Shah Tughluq had been on the sultan's throne for a little less than a year. Under his uncle's cruel and careless rule, the sultanate had drastically shrunk; the early part of his rule was more concerned with matters at home than with enemies beyond Delhi's current borders. His biographer, Shams-i Siraj, tells us that he began his reign by making massive government loans to the people of Delhi "for the purpose of restoring the land, villages, and the quarters which had fallen into ruin during the days of famine," and then forgiving the loans.[1]

This was good domestic policy, and Firoz Shah was rewarded with the loyalty of his subjects; during his entire reign, Siraj says, "not one leaf of dominion was shaken in the palace of sovereignty. . . . Everyone had plenty of gold and silver. . . . Wealth abounded and comforts were general. The whole realm of Delhi was blessed with the bounties of the Almighty. . . . These facts are among the glories of his reign."[2]